

On the other hand, if you are not too eager for very good quality, you can reduce the sampling rate to 80 Kbps. Such a sampling rate will serve the purpose for most spoken words. In fact, if it is a live recording of a speech or a radio broadcast you can even use 64 Kbps sampling rate.

 Staying away from Stereo mode

If you are encoding MP3s, then you should stay away from the Intensity Stereo Coding or Joint Stereo option. These features normally take away information that is common to both channels and encodes the MP3 in mono and thereby saves on storage space.



The Diamond Multimedia MP3 player

It's better to avoid such effects as it messes up the quality of the sound and you may face compatibility problems with some players.

 Don't reduce frequency

In our efforts to make an MP3 file smaller, we often cut many corners that are not actually worth it. One of these gimmicks is cutting off all frequencies above 10 KHz or 12 KHz.

Agreed, this may reduce the file size but what it also does is drastically reduce the quality of the sound to a level where some of the reproduction or

distortion in the bass or treble become clearly audible.

 Creating MP3s from cassettes and LPs

It's not necessary that you always have to rip a CD to create an MP3. You can create the same using your ordinary tape (cassette) or the LPs that have been kept in safe custody. All you need is a soundcard on your machine with a line-in option and an adapter cable that will go into the line-in on the soundcard end and the line-out on the LP or tape end.

Then using software such as Easy CD creator, you can start the process of recording from the tape or LP. Most software will also identify the breaks between songs and therefore save the different tracks as separate files.

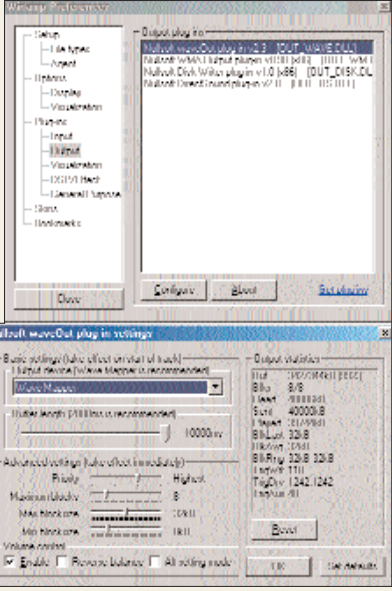
Just ensure that before you start the process, the Line-in option of your soundcard is enabled and not muted. You can check this out by double-clicking on the volume icon in the taskbar.

Software for MP3s

There are a number of software that allow you to encode MP3s as well as play them. We look at some of the popular ones fare.

 Encoding with Winamp

Winamp is one of the more popular media players around and you can even rip and encode from audio CD tracks to MP3s. Before you do that, however, you have to check whether the CD reader plugin for Winamp is installed, whether the Nullsoft MP3 output plugin is present and that the Fraunhofer ACM Pro Codec installed. Once all these are present, select the CD tracks in the playlist and rename them manually. Then go to Preferences > Output Plug-ins, and select the option to configure Nullsoft MP3 output plugin. This basically involves selecting the directory to save the files. Ensure that you have not selected shuffle and repeat from your Winamp preferences. Now, when you click on the Play button, the process of ripping the tracks that have been selected in the playlist and



Encoding MP3s in Winamp

encoding them to MP3 starts. It gets saved in the directory you specified. If you want, you can separate the two processes and first rip the CD (this creates the Wav files) and then encode the Wav files to MP3s.

 Improving MP3 sound quality in Winamp

If you have been using the Nitrate decoder to play MP3 files in Winamp, then you may have on occasion felt that the quality isn't the best that's possible. So use the Fraunhofer decoder to play the MP3 files. It's possible to download the decoder and use it with your version of Winamp for the best sound quality.

 Enhancing speed and quality in Winamp

Tweaking a few preferences will get Winamp working faster and better. Go to the Winamp preferences using the shortcut key, [Ctrl] + [P]. Go to the Setup menu and click on File Types.

Now, click on the Select All option. In the main menu click again on Options. You will find an option for 'process priority class' with a slider bar. You should move the slider to Real-time. Other

Ad will come